



YOU ARE **22 WEEKS AND 4 DAYS**

122 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

Seeing your baby on a 3-D or 4-D scan gives you a better view, but most of the information that enables doctors to plan your care comes from looking inside your baby using 2-D ultrasound, which provides the clearest images of internal structures.

“Now that they can hear, your amazing baby is starting to develop the ability to remember things, too.”

As your baby's nervous system develops, and especially once their sense of hearing evolves, they have the opportunity to learn and remember from experience. How this process develops is not fully understood, but experts believe that the first signs of learning coincide with the unborn baby's ability to hear, at around this midstage of pregnancy.

In later months, more sound will reach your baby as the walls of the uterus become thinner. Although babies have been seen to be startled by a noise at this stage, they seem to learn not to react to the sound if it is repeated again and again, gradually adapting to it as it's repeated over time, and eventually ignoring it.

This simple test demonstrates that a fetus can adapt to a repeated stimulus. If, however, the sound pattern is not repeated for some time, your baby will have forgotten it and become startled by it if it occurs again.

Retaining a memory for events is a much more complex function and relies on pathways in the gray matter of the brain. It will be weeks before learning and memory are linked in the last stages of your pregnancy.

At this stage of pregnancy, your baby is likely to be more active and predictable in their movements. Around this time you're likely to start feeling regular, more definite movements and become accustomed to your baby's activities.

UP CLOSE AND PERSONAL

It's possible to see what your unborn baby will look like. Private ultrasound scans enable parents to see their baby up close either in 3-D, as a still image, or 4-D, as a moving picture.

Clear scans of the baby's facial features can be seen from around this week. However, the optimum time to have one of these scans is between 26 and 34 weeks, when your baby still has room to move around easily.

You will be able to see an amazing level of detail that won't be visible on a standard ultrasound scan. Don't forget to inform the ultrasound technician if you don't want to know the sex of your baby, since it is likely to be very clear on these high-tech scans.